



Napoleon diamond necklace

△ **Emperor Napoleon I** in a portrait by François Gérard (detail), c.1805–15

Commissioned by Napoleon I of France in 1811 for his wife Empress Marie-Louise to celebrate the birth of their son, this necklace is composed of 234 diamonds. The single thread is set with 28 mine-cut (the earliest form of brilliant-cut) diamonds. A second tier has nine pendeloques and 10 briolettes (teardrop-shaped cuts).

Napoleon had divorced the Empress Josephine, who had failed to give him an heir, and married Archduchess Marie-Louise of Austria in 1810. Napoleon's son was born within a year, and he duly commissioned the Parisian jewellers Etienne Nitot et fils to produce the 376,274-franc necklace, a sum equal to the Empress's entire annual

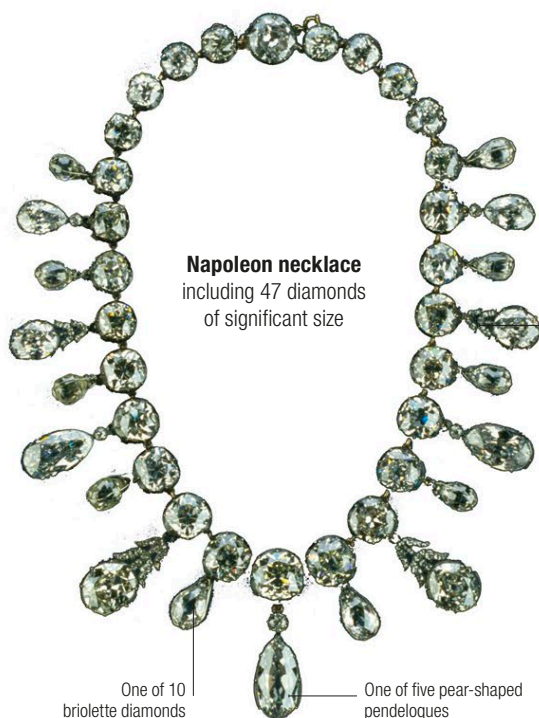


Maria Theresa of Portugal, who inherited the necklace in 1914

household budget. Marie-Louise wore the necklace in several contemporary portraits and kept it until her death.

Maria Theresa, a princess of Portugal, eventually inherited it and, in 1929, decided to sell. She engaged two agents, "Colonel Townsend" and "Princess Baronti", to sell the necklace for \$450,000. As the stock market had just crashed, this figure proved unrealistic and the agents began offers at \$100,000, enlisting Archduke Leopold

of Hapsburg, Maria Theresa's penniless grandnephew, to give assurances of authenticity to buyers. The necklace eventually sold for \$60,000, but the agents and Archduke Leopold claimed a collective fee of \$53,730 as expenses. Maria Theresa took the matter to court, recovered the necklace, and Leopold was jailed. The "Townsend" evaded capture, however, and their true identities remain a mystery.



Napoleon necklace including 47 diamonds of significant size

Motif set with 23 small diamonds attached to each of four ovaline pendeloques

Key dates

1811–1962

June 12, 1811 Napoleon commissions the necklace to celebrate his son's birth

1800

20 March, 1811

Napoleon's son, Napoleon François-Joseph Charles, is born to Marie-Louise

1872 On Sophie's death, the necklace is inherited by her sons, archdukes Karl Ludwig, Ludwig Viktor, and Franz Joseph of Austria

1850

1847 Marie-Louise dies. The necklace passes to Archduchess Sophie of Austria. Two diamonds are removed for earrings

1900

1914 The necklace passes to Karl Ludwig's third wife, Maria Theresa of Portugal, on his death



Paul-Louis Weiller and his wife at the Academy of Fine Arts, Paris, 1965

1920

1929 Maria Theresa tries to sell the necklace, but recovers it after an attempt to swindle her out of the proceeds

1940

1944 Maria Theresa dies

1948 The Hapsburg family sells the necklace to French industrialist Paul-Louis Weiller

1960

1960 Harry Winston buys the necklace from Weiller and later sells it to Marjorie Merriweather Post

1962 Post donates the necklace to the Smithsonian Institution. It remains on display at the National Museum of Natural History, Washington DC

1980

Thirteen... diamonds are type IIa [almost completely pure]... consistent with the jewel's imperial pedigree

Drs **E Gaillou** and **J Post**

National Museum of Natural History, Smithsonian Institution